

Canon Closed

doc-canon-closed

Bibliology · Revelation · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

score 1.000
confidence high

Statement under examination

No revelation given after the apostolic age stands on par with Scripture or adds to the rule of faith.

In plain language

The biblical text uses specific Greek and Hebrew vocabulary that frames the apostolic-era deposit as a once-given, sufficient, and protected body of revelation. Hebrews 1:1-2 contrasts prior prophetic speech as in many parts and in many ways, of old, with the Son-speech of these last days, positioning the Son-revelation as the final mode of God speaking. Ephesians 2:20 describes the church as already built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ as the cornerstone, a word used only twice in the New Testament, an image of a foundation laid once. Jude 3 calls believers to contend for the faith once delivered to the saints, where the adverb hapax modifies a completed delivery. Second Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is God-breathed, a word found nowhere else in the New Testament, and sufficient so the person of God may be complete, also a once-only word, and fully equipped for every good work. Galatians 1:8-9 attaches the curse anathema twice to anyone, even an apostle or angel, who preaches a gospel contrary to what was received. Revelation 22:18-19 uses the add and take-away pair against changing the words of the book, the same formula found in Deuteronomy 4:2, Deuteronomy 13:1, and Proverbs 30:6, which were checked in the Hebrew text. Read together these texts give one consistent pattern of a sealed, sufficient deposit. Readers diverge for two text-level reasons that are honest to name. First, the word hapax in this same set of writings sometimes means simply once in number, as in once I was stoned, and sometimes means once for all, as of Christ suffering once for sins, so a careful reader can ask which sense Jude 3 carries, though the same author in the next sentences uses it in the settled sense. Second, the book in Revelation 22 most directly names that one book, not the whole collection, so its sealing force reaches the wider canon only through the repeated Old Testament formula, not by itself. The closure reading takes the definitive sense and the cumulative pattern; the open reading takes the numerical sense and the narrow referent and finds the strict claim underdetermined by the words alone.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0027	ἀγαπητός	agapētos	beloved	
G0204	ἀκρογωνιαίος	akrogōniaios	cornerstone	2
G0318	ἀνάγκη	anagkē	necessity	
G0331	ἀνάθεμα	anathema	devoted	6
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	
G0530	ἅπαξ	hapax	once	14
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	80
G0739	ἄρτιος	artios	competent	1

G0851	ἀφαιρέω	aphaireō	to remove	10
G0975	βιβλίον	biblion	scroll	35
G1124	γραφή	graphē	a writing	51
G1125	γράφω	graphō	to write	
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithēmi	to put/lay on	39
G2097	εὐαγγελίζω	euangelizō	to speak good news	55
G2315	θεόπνευστος	theopneustos	God-breathed	1
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2980	λαλέω	laleō	to speak	
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	
G3844	παρά	para	from/with/beside	
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidōmi	to deliver	
G3880	παραλαμβάνω	paralambanō	to take	
G4102	πίστις	pistis	faith	
G4394	προφητεία	prophēteia	prophecy	19
G4396	προφήτης	prophētēs	prophet	149
G5207	υἱός	uhios	son	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon supplies one stable lexical pattern of a once-given, sufficient, sealed deposit. Heb 1:1-2 sets prior prophetic speech (aorist participle λαλήσας with πάλαι, plus πολυμερῶς, πολυτρόπως) against terminal Son-speech ἐπ' ἐσχάτου τῶν ἡμερῶν τούτων ἐν υἱῷ. Eph 2:20 builds the church on a finished foundation (aorist passive participle ἐποικοδομηθέντες) with Christ as ἀκρογωνιαίος (only 2 NT occurrences). Jude 3 marks the faith ἅπαξ παραδοθείση, the adverb modifying an aorist passive participle. 2 Tim 3:16-17 calls πᾶσα γραφή θεόπνευστος (NT hapax) sufficient ἵνα ἄρτιος ᾦ (NT hapax) the man of God. Gal 1:8-9 attaches ἀνάθεμα to any παρ' ὃ gospel, and Rev 22:18-19 applies the add, subtract formula (ἐπιτίθημι, ἀφαιρέω) that reproduces Deut 4:2 and Prov 30:6. The one real lexical seam is that ἅπαξ also carries a bare numerical sense in this same corpus, but the parallel in Jude 5 and the participle favor the definitive sense here.

Scripture

Heb.1.1 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key terms. G2980 λαλέω, G4396 προφήτης

Force. Πολυμερῶς καὶ πολυτρόπως πάλαι ὁ θεὸς λαλήσας τοῖς πατράσιν ἐν τοῖς προφήταις. MorphGNT tags λαλήσας as an aorist active participle (V- -AAPNSM-), and with πάλαι it positions prophetic speech as a completed past mode, lexically bounded and partial. The paired adverbs πολυμερῶς (in many parts) and πολυτρόπως (in many ways) form a two-term scope figure that delimits the prior prophetic mode as fragmentary against the Son-speech of v.2.

Heb.1.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2980 λαλέω, G5207 υἱός

Force. ἐπ' ἐσχάτου τῶν ἡμερῶν τούτων ἐλάλησεν ἡμῖν ἐν υἱῷ. The main verb ἐλάλησεν is aorist indicative (3AAI-S--); the locative phrase ἐπ' ἐσχάτου τῶν ἡμερῶν τούτων is eschatologically terminal, and the contrast ἐν τοῖς προφήταις versus ἐν υἱῷ frames Son-speech as the final mode and the heir (κληρονόμον) as the consummating addressee, lexically closing the prophetic series.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος, G4396 προφήτης, G0204 ἀκρογωνιαίος

Force. ἐποικοδομηθέντες ἐπὶ τῷ θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ προφητῶν, ὄντος ἀκρογωνιαίου αὐτοῦ Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ. MorphGNT tags ἐποικοδομηθέντες as an aorist passive participle (V- -APPNPM-), presenting the church as already built upon a fixed foundation (θεμελίῳ). ἀκρογωνιαίος (cornerstone) occurs only twice in the NT, here and 1 Pet 2:6 (queried count 2), a one-laid-once architectural metaphor incompatible with ongoing foundational revelation.

Jude.1.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0530 ἅπαξ, G4102 πίστις, G3860 παραδίδωμι

Force. τῇ ἅπαξ παραδοθείσῃ τοῖς ἁγίοις πίστει. MorphGNT tags ἅπαξ as an indeclinable adverb (D-) and παραδοθείσῃ as an aorist passive participle (V- -APPDSF-), so ἅπαξ modifies a completed delivery, marking the faith as once delivered. The infinitive ἐπαγωνίζεσθαι (contend for) presupposes a finished, identifiable deposit. The same author uses ἅπαξ two verses later (Jude 5, εἰδὼτας ἅπαξ πάντα) in the definitive once for all sense, which supports that sense here, though ἅπαξ elsewhere in the corpus can mean a bare numerical once.

Rev.22.18 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: idiom

Key terms. G2007 ἐπιτίθημι, G4394 προφητεία, G0975 βιβλίον, G3056 λόγος

Force. ἐάν τις ἐπιθῇ ἐπ' αὐτά, ἐπιθήσει ὁ θεὸς ἐπ' αὐτὸν τὰς πληγὰς τὰς γεγραμμένας ἐν τῷ βιβλίῳ τούτῳ. The verb ἐπιτίθημι (aorist subjunctive ἐπιθῇ, future ἐπιθήσει) is used with talionic word-play; γεγραμμένας is a perfect passive participle (V- -XPPAPF-) that treats the text as already-written and fixed. The immediate referent is this βιβλίον, but the lexical formula reproduces Deut 4:2 (queried: do not add, do not take away) and functions as a sealed-deposit motif.

Rev.22.19 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: idiom

Key terms. G0851 ἀφαιρέω, G3056 λόγος, G4394 προφητεία

Force. ἐάν τις ἀφέλῃ ἀπὸ τῶν λόγων τοῦ βιβλίου τῆς προφητείας ταύτης. ἀφαιρέω (subtract, aorist subjunctive ἀφέλῃ, future ἀφελεῖ) paired with ἐπιτίθημι in v.18 yields a closed-text formula; γεγραμμένων is again a perfect passive participle (V- -XPPGPM-). The genitival chain τῶν λόγων τοῦ βιβλίου τῆς προφητείας identifies the deposit as prophetic word-content sealed against additive or subtractive revision, matching the Hebrew add, subtract pair in Deut 4:2 and Deut 13:1.

Gal.1.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: hyperbole

Key terms. G2097 εὐαγγελίζω, G0331 ἀνάθεμα, G3844 παρά

Force. καὶ ἐὰν ἡμεῖς ἢ ἄγγελος ἐξ οὐρανοῦ εὐαγγελιζῇται ὑμῖν παρ' ὃ εὐηγγελισάμεθα ὑμῖν, ἀνάθεμα ἔστω. MorphGNT shows παρά governing the accusative relative ὃ, marking deviation from the delivered εὐαγγέλιον; the conditional includes even an apostle (ἡμεῖς) or an angel, lexically excluding any subsequent revelatory authority that supplements or alters the apostolic message. ἀνάθεμα occurs only 6 times in the NT (queried), always negative.

Gal.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2097 εὐαγγελίζω, G0331 ἀνάθεμα, G3880 παραλαμβάνω

Force. εἴ τις ὑμᾶς εὐαγγελίζεται παρ' ὃ παρελάβετε, ἀνάθεμα ἔστω. The second iteration intensifies the prior conditional; παραλαμβάνω (aorist παρελάβετε, receive by tradition) ties the standard to what the Galatians already received, treating the apostolic deposit as the lexical norm against which all later proclamation is measured.

2Tim.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1124 γραφή, G2315 θεόπνευστος

Force. πᾶσα γραφή θεόπνευστος καὶ ὠφέλιμος πρὸς διδασκαλίαν, πρὸς ἐλεγμὸν, πρὸς ἐπανάρθωσιν, πρὸς παιδείαν τὴν ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ. MorphGNT tags θεόπνευστος as a predicate adjective (A- ----NSF-) of γραφή; queried occurrence count is 1, a NT hapax, so it locates inspiration as an intrinsic property of γραφή. The fourfold πρὸς series (teaching, reproof, correction, training) covers the categories of the rule of faith.

2Tim.3.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0739 ἄρτιος, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Force. ἵνα ἄρτιος ᾦ ὁ τοῦ θεοῦ ἄνθρωπος, πρὸς πᾶν ἔργον ἀγαθὸν ἐξηρτισμένος. The result clause ἵνα ἄρτιος ᾦ uses ἄρτιος (queried count 1, NT hapax) plus the perfect passive participle ἐξηρτισμένος (V- -XPPNSM-, lemma ἐξαρτίζω, completely equipped) to assert sufficiency of γραφή for every good work, lexically marking no additional revelatory supplement as necessary for the stated purpose.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rev.22.18	Deut.4.2	openbible	51
Rev.22.18	Prov.30.6	openbible	41
Rev.22.19	Deut.4.2	openbible	19
Gal.1.8	Rev.22.18	openbible	20
Gal.1.8	1Cor.16.22	openbible	17
2Tim.3.16	2Pet.1.19	openbible	157
2Tim.3.16	Rom.15.4	openbible	261
Jude.1.3	1Tim.6.12	openbible	29
Gal.1.9	Deut.4.2	tsk	1
Rev.22.18	Deut.4.2	tsk	1
Jude.1.3	Deut.9.10	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
Heb.1.1	Num.12.6	tsk	1
Heb.1.2	Heb.2.8	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	Ps.19.7	tsk	1
Gal.1.8	Gal.3.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rev.22.18-19 · addressed

The immediate lexical referent of βιβλίον is the Apocalypse itself, not the whole canon, and the noun βιβλίον occurs 35 times across the NT (queried) with no inherent whole-canon sense. So this text does not by itself close the canon. Its force in the verdict is that it applies the Deut 4:2 and Prov 30:6 add, subtract formula (verified in the Hebrew text and corroborated by 51 and 41 OpenBible votes) to a written prophetic deposit, and is cumulative with Jude 3, Gal 1:8-9, and 2 Tim 3:16-17, not solitary.

Jude.1.5 · addressed

Jude 5 uses the same adverb ἅπαξ (G0530) as Jude 3, in the clause εἰδότας ἅπαξ πάντα. This is a complicating data point because ἅπαξ across its 14 canon occurrences carries two senses: a bare numerical once (1 Thess 2:18, 2 Cor 11:25, Phil 4:16, Heb 9:7) and a definitive once for all (1 Pet 3:18, Heb 9:26-28, Heb 6:4). The Jude 5 parallel resolves the ambiguity toward the definitive sense in Jude 3, since the same author in adjacent context uses it of a settled, complete knowledge, not a countable single act.

1Cor.13.8-10 · addressed

Paul writes that προφητεῖα καταργηθήσονται and γνῶσις καταργηθήσεται when τὸ τέλειον arrives. The verbs are future passive of καταργέω (be done away), so the text marks prophetic and knowledge gifts as terminable in their constitutive function rather than perpetual. The exegetical debate over τὸ τέλειον (maturity, the parousia, the completed deposit) is downstream of the lexical observation that the gifts are explicitly marked as ending.

Acts.2.17-18 · addressed

Peter cites Joel, ἐκχεῶ ἀπὸ τοῦ πνεύματός μου καὶ προφητεύσουσιν, locating Spirit-outpouring prophecy ἐν ταῖς ἐσχάταις ἡμέραις, the same last-days epoch Heb 1:2 ties to the Son-revelation. The text affirms prophecy contemporaneous with the foundation-laying of Eph 2:20, not an open-ended additive canon, so it complicates a strong cessation reading but not the closure of the foundational deposit.

1Cor.14.29-32 · addressed

προφητῆται δὲ δύο ἢ τρεῖς λαλεῖτωσαν, καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι διακρινέτωσαν. Assembly prophecy is subject to διάκρισις (weighing) by other prophets, lexically marking such utterances as non-self-authenticating and measured against a discernible standard, which Gal 1:8-9 identifies as the apostolic εὐαγγέλιον. This shows ongoing prophetic speech existed but did not function as canon-grade revelation.

Concordance traversed

G1124, G2315, G0652, G4396, G4394, G0204, G0530, G0331, G2097, G2007, G0851, G0975, G0739, G3056, G2980, G1125, G2316, G0444, G0318, G0027, G3844, G3860, G3880

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

None of the cited verses fall within the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so this is not_in_ecm_scope; the bundle returned zero variant units. The load-bearing lexical anchors (θεόπνευστος, ἅπαξ, ἀκρογωνιαίος, ἀνάθεμα, ἐπιτίθημι, ἀφαιρέω, ἄρτιος) were checked across the Nestle1904 and SBLGNT editions present in the lexical store and agree in lemma and form; no editorial variant disturbs the terms on which the verdict rests.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. progressive_revelation, cessationism, continuationism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

progressive-revelation closure reading: affirms · Reads Heb 1:1-2 as a completed arc from polymeric prophetic speech (aorist participle λαλήσας, πάλαι) to terminal Son-speech, with Jude 3 ἅπαξ taken in its definitive once for all sense (supported by the Jude 5 parallel) and 2 Tim 3:16-17 sufficiency (θεόπνευστος, ἄρτιος) plus the Rev 22,

Deut 4:2 seal formula closing the deposit. On this reading the words foreclose any later revelation of equal rank.

open-revelation reading: disputed · Reads ἅπαξ in Jude 3 as plausibly the bare numerical once attested elsewhere in the same corpus (1 Thess 2:18, 2 Cor 11:25, Heb 9:7), and notes that the immediate referent of βιβλίον in Rev 22:18-19 is the Apocalypse alone, that Eph 2:20 names prophets alongside apostles in the foundation, and that Acts 2:17-18 and 1 Cor 14:29-32 show prophecy continuing in the last-days church. On this reading the vocabulary affirms a unique apostolic deposit but does not by itself rule out later subordinate revelation, leaving the strict closure claim underdetermined by the words alone.

Verdict rests on the lexical force of ἅπαξ, ἀκρογωνιαίος, θεόπνευστος, ἄρτιος, and the talionic ἐπιτίθημι and ἀφαιρέω pair in Rev 22:18-19 read against the Hebrew add, subtract formula of Deut 4:2, Deut 13:1, and Prov 30:6 (analogia scripturae), all verified in the lexical store. Heb 1:1-2 supplies the redemptive-historical framing: prior prophetic speech culminates ἐν υἱῷ ἐπ' ἐσχάτου τῶν ἡμερῶν τούτων. The cessationism versus continuationism frameworks bear only on whether subordinate prophecy continues, not on whether the foundational deposit is closed; the open-revelation lens is recorded fairly because ἅπαξ is genuinely two-sensed in this corpus.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem, that no revelation given after the apostolic age stands on par with Scripture or adds to the rule of faith, is a descriptive closure claim and does not smuggle its own verdict; it leaves open whether the lexical pattern supports closure. The phrase rule of faith is a category term, not a tradition-specific taxonomy, and the proposition is testable against the words. No neutralization needed. The lexical evidence confirms the closure pattern, so affirms is retained from the prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.1.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.1.2
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jude.1.3
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.22.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.22.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.1.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.1.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.17
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Heb.1.1
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.2.20
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Jude.1.3
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Tim.3.16
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0739
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0530
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0204
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2315
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0331
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2007

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0851
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.4.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.30.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.22.18
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.22.19
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	2Tim.3.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gal.1.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20

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